Lesson Plan One

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Asking for a Raise by Email (Real-Life Workplace Communication)

What Is "Beneath" the Lesson Plan: Principles of Method and Rationale

Low-intermediate adult ESL learners can generally write simple sentences but may struggle to connect ideas coherently and make requests in polite, professional language. Following Brown and Lee's (2015) teaching principle, this lesson adopts Task-Based Instruction (TBI), which emphasizes using language to accomplish meaningful tasks with clear outcomes (Ellis, 2003; Larsen-Freeman & Anderson, 2011). Rather than learning adverb clauses solely through isolated grammar exercises, learners apply these structures to a workplace communication task: writing an email to a supervisor requesting a discussion about a raise and responding to a partner's email while assuming the role of the supervisor. The task prioritizes meaningful communication, with success determined by the clarity, politeness, organization, and grammatical accuracy of the messages.

The lesson follows the task cycle of pre-task, task, and post-task (Willis, 1996; Ellis, 2003). During the pre-task, the teacher activates learners' prior knowledge, establishes the workplace context, and briefly reviews what was taught in the previous lesson, which introduced the target grammatical form: adverb clauses. During the task stage, learners use job cards, a planning sheet, and a word bank to compose their emails, exchange messages with partners, and write replies. The post-task brings attention to form through error analysis and revision.

Although the lesson focuses on adverb clauses of cause, contrast, and condition, it is important to teach them in relation to real-world examples for their communication purposes. This is why task-based instruction is suitable for this lesson because it connects language learning to a practical communicative goal. Adverb clauses arise naturally in the email: cause (*because*) gives the reasons for the request, contrast (*although, even though, while*)

acknowledges the company's situation politely, and condition (*unless, even if, whether or not*) shows flexibility and what the writer can offer. Also, through interaction and the exchange of written messages, which is relevant to Long's (1996) interactionist perspectives on SLA, learners can exchange emails and respond to one another; they also have the opportunity to clarify meaning and communicate in a way that is easy for readers to understand. The teacher supports this process by monitoring students' progress and providing assistance when necessary.

Finally, the lesson focuses on form after the communicative task. The teacher collects errors from students' writing and teaches from them after the task (sentence fragments beginning with "because," comma misuse, double connectors, and impolite tone). Revision after feedback and repeats the writing task as an assignment to improve accuracy and fluency. The lesson also draws on features of the Sheltered Instruction Observation Protocol (SIOP), including explicit content and language objectives, modeling, scaffolding, meaningful interaction, and review of learning objectives (Center for Applied Linguistics, n.d.; Echevarría et al., 2017).

Context and Student Population

- **Student demographic:** 18 Adult Intensive ESL
- **Settings:** Hawkeye Community College Adult Learning Center
- **Proficiency Level:** B2 (Intermediate)
- **Time:** 50 Minutes (meets 3 times a week)
- **Method:** Task-Based Instruction (TBI)

Learner Needs: Students can write simple sentences, but they need help connecting their ideas to make requests politely in real-world contexts. They face common challenges like sentence fragments beginning with "because", comma errors, double connectors like "although… but,"

and sometimes, they might sound too direct. Since the class is three times a week, in the previous class, students were introduced to adverb clauses of cause, contrast, and condition.

Course Goals

By the end of the course, students will be able to communicate clearly in real-life workplace and academic situations (such as emails and short messages) and in short academic essays, use complex sentences accurately, and revise their writing using feedback from peers and the teacher.

Learning Objectives

Goal of the lesson: To help students communicate in a real-life workplace situation by writing a clear, polite email to their supervisors, discussing a raise using adverb clauses of cause, contrast, and condition accurately.

Content Objectives: Students will:

- write a clear, polite email to your boss requesting a discussion about a raise.
- reply to a coworker's request with a decision and a reason.
- revise their email so that it is clear, polite, and professional.

Language Objectives: Students will:

- use at least four adverb clauses of cause, contrast, and condition (e.g., *because, although, even though, unless, even if*) accurately and appropriately in their email.
- identify the type of adverb clause (cause, contrast, or condition) in sentences they hear and read.
- avoid sentence fragments beginning with because and avoid double connectors.

Key Concepts and Vocabulary:

- **Adverb clause words:** cause: *because*; contrast: *although, even though, while*; condition: *unless, even if, whether or no.*
- **Nouns:** raise, salary, responsibilities, request, budget.
- **Verbs and phrases:** ask for, discuss, appreciate, consider, would like to.

Materials and Equipment

projector or slides, whiteboard and markers, sentence strips, job cards, email planning sheet and word bank, model email, peer-review and reply sheet, common-error examples, assessment rubric, and bilingual dictionaries.

Before class, the teacher should:

- Prepare and display the content and language objectives
- Prepare the slides, sentence strips, and job cards.
- Print the planning sheet, model email, and peer review and reply sheet (one per student).
- Prepare the rubric based on use of adverb clauses, clear and polite message, organization, and grammar and punctuation.

Lesson Procedures: (50 minutes)

Motivation (Pre-Task, 5 minutes):

- Students read the lesson objectives silently, then read them aloud together.
- The teacher displays this situation: “You have worked at your job for one year. You now do more tasks than when you started, but your salary is still the same.”
- The teacher asks students these questions: “What would you do? Whom would you contact? What would you say?
- Student turn to their partner to discuss these questions and how they would ask for a raise at their workplace

- The teacher explains that students will write a request email and reply to a partner's email.

Review and Model (Pre-Task, 12 minutes):

- Quick review: Show a chart of the three adverb clause types and review one example of each. **(Appendix A)**
- Review the comma rule: use a comma after an adverb clause at the beginning of a sentence; a comma is usually not needed when the clause comes at the end.
- In pairs, students sort six sentence strips into cause, contrast, and condition **(Appendix A).**
- Check the answers with the whole class and correct quickly. Point to the word bank **(Appendix C).**

Model the task

The teacher explains and models the task and expectations. Students will write an email to their supervisor requesting a raise, including reasons, a contrast, and a condition (at least 4 adverbial clauses). Then a partner will reply as the boss.

- The teacher reads the model email on the slides **(Appendix D)** aloud. Students underline the adverb clauses and name their types.
- The teacher points out polite language (*I would like to…*, *I would appreciate…*).
- The teacher explains how to use the planning sheet and word bank, reminds students to avoid fragments beginning with because, and to punctuate opening clauses correctly.
- Each student draws a job card **(Appendix B)** and predicts which clause type will be used for each piece of information (reason, company situation, offer).

Main Task (Task, 23 minutes):

- Students use their job cards and planning sheets to plan their ideas. **(Appendix B&C)**
- Students write their emails independently, using the word bank and sentence frames as needed.
- The teacher moves around, monitors the students' progress, and provides support when necessary.
- After some minutes, students exchange their emails with their partners
- Each partner reads the email as if they were the supervisor and completes the peer-review checklist. **(Appendix E).**
- The partner then writes a reply of two or three sentences with a decision and a reason, using at least one adverb clause, and returns it.
- Several students read their request and the reply aloud. The class says whether the request was accepted and which adverb clauses made the message clear and polite.

Feedback and Review (Post-Task, 10 minutes):

- Review common errors: the teacher shows common errors from student writing (anonymously) on slides (Appendix F): The fragments beginning with *because*, comma misuse, double connectors, wrong tense in the clause, and impolite tone.
- Students identify each error and suggest a correction, and the teacher explains using correct models.
- Students revise their emails using the feedback and the peer review sheet.
- One to three volunteers read a revised sentence that shows accurate use of an adverb clause.
- Students return to the objectives and assess whether they met them,

Homework:

Students finish revising their email. Then they write a second email about a different real situation (for example, asking a supervisor to change a work schedule or asking an advisor for an appointment) that uses at least four adverb clauses. Students bring both emails to the next class.

Assessment

Assessment is formative, and it takes place throughout the lesson

- Pre-task: The teacher checks prior knowledge through the sorting activity and listens to pair discussion to note areas needing clarification.
- Task: The teacher circulates and gives brief support. Partners use the peer review and reply sheet (Appendix E) to check use of clauses, clarity, and politeness.
- Post-task: The teacher checks revisions and listens to volunteer examples for improved accuracy.

References

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Appendix A: Review chart and sentence strips

Type		**Words**	**Example**
Cause	give a reason	*because*	I am asking for a raise *because I train new employees now*.
Contrast	show an unexpected or opposite idea	*although, even though, while*	*Although the budget is tight*, I believe my work has grown.
Condition	say what depends on something	*unless, even if, whether or not*	I can work extra shifts *unless I have class*.

Comma rule: When the adverb clause comes at the beginning of the sentence, put a comma after it. When it comes at the end, usually do not use a comma.

Sentence strip	**Answer**
I am asking for a raise because I train new employees now.	**Cause**
Although the budget is tight, I believe my work has grown.	**Contrast**
I can take extra shifts unless I have a class.	**Conditions**
While I understand the company had a slow year, I would like to discuss my salary.	**Contrast**
Even if a raise is not possible now, I would like your feedback.	**Condition**

Appendix B. Job cards

Cut into six cards. Each student draws one card and uses the information in the three columns.

Card	Job	Reason (cause)	Company situation (contrast)	What I can offer (condition)
1	Cashier	I now train new employees.	The store had a slow season.	I can work extra weekend shifts.
2	Receptionist	I now manage the schedule and answer more calls.	The clinic budget is tight.	I can learn the new billing system.
3	Delivery driver	My routes have doubled.	Fuel costs have gone up.	I can cover busy days.
4	Cook	I now lead the kitchen team on weekends.	Sales were low last month.	I can train new staff.
5	Office assistant	I now write customer emails and weekly reports.	The company gave no raises this year.	I can take a customer service course.
6	Warehouse worker	I learned to use the new machines.	The warehouse is short of staff.	I can become the safety trainer.

Appendix C. Student worksheet: Email planning sheet

Name: _____ Job card: _____

Step 1. Plan your ideas

Part	Sentence frame	Your sentence
Reason (cause)	I would like to discuss a raise **because** _____.	
Contrast	**Although / Even though / While** _____, _____.	

Part	Sentence frame	Your sentence
Condition	I can _____ **unless / even if / whether or not** _____	

Step 2. Write your email.

To: _____

Subject: _____

Dear Mr. / Ms. _____,

I am writing to ask if we can discuss _____. _____ _____ _____ _____

Thank you for considering my request.

Sincerely,

Polite phrases: I would like to… / I would appreciate… / I am happy to… / Thank you for your time.

Word bank

Cause	**Contrast**	**Condition**
because	although, even though, while	unless, even if, whether or not

Appendix D. Model email

Subject: Request to discuss my salary

Dear Mr. Carter,

I am writing to ask if we can discuss a raise **because I have taken on more responsibilities since January**. **Although I know the company budget is limited this year**, I believe my work

now supports the team in new ways. I am happy to meet at any time that works for you, **unless you are traveling next week**. **Even if a raise is not possible right now**, I would appreciate your feedback on how I can grow in this role.

Thank you for considering my request.

Sincerely,

Maria

Teacher note: Students underline the adverb clauses (shown in bold) and name each type: cause, contrast, condition.

Appendix E. Pair review sheet

Part 1. Review (the partner reads as the boss)

Question	**Yes**	**Needs work**
Is the request clear?	☐	☐
Is there a reason with *because*?	☐	☐
Is there a contrast clause (*although, even though, while*)?	☐	☐
Is there a condition clause (*unless, even if, whether or not*)?	☐	☐
Is there a comma after a clause at the beginning of a sentence?	☐	☐
Is the email polite and professional?	☐	☐

One thing I liked: _____

One thing to improve: _____

Appendix F: Common Errors for Post-Task Slides (Samples)

The teacher replaces or adds errors from real student writing from the lesson. Each sample shows the error and the correction.

Error type	Error	Correction
Fragment	I deserve a raise. Because I work hard.	I deserve a raise because I work hard.
Missing comma	Although the budget is small I have more work.	Although the budget is small, I have more work.
Double connector	Although the budget is small, but I work hard.	Although the budget is small, I work hard.
Tense in the clause	Unless you will be busy, I would like to meet next week.	Unless you are busy, I would like to meet next week.
Tone	Even if you say no, I will quit.	Even if a raise is not possible now, I would appreciate your feedback.